JOURNEY THROUGH JONAH

Small-group kit

Four sessions for home groups and small groups – one per chapter, 75 to 90 minutes each. Each session builds on that week's devotionals.

SESSION 1	On the Run	Jonah 1:1–16
SESSION 2	From the Depths	Jonah 2:1–11
SESSION 3	Overturned	Jonah 3:1–10
SESSION 4	The Unanswered Question	Jonah 4:1–11

Scripture: own translation from the Hebrew (Masoretic Text) by Dr. Johannes (Hannes) A. Nortjé. Verse numbers follow the Hebrew text.
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SESSION 1 · JONAH 1:1–16

On the Run

THE BIG IDEA

God's call does not let go of us when we run – he sends a storm of grace that brings us, and those around us, back to him.

TO GET STARTED

As a child, what did you do to get out of a chore you didn't want to do – and did it work?

READ TOGETHER · JONAH 1:1–16

Read with four voices: a narrator, the LORD, the captain, and the sailors (as a group) – Jonah's own lines can be read by a fifth person.

TIMING

10 min	Welcome & opener
10 min	Read the passage
10 min	Background & Hebrew
40 min	Discussion
15 min	Application & prayer

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

Jonah was a well-known prophet in Israel who had announced good news for his own nation (2 Kings 14:25). Now God sends him to Nineveh, a capital of the brutal Assyrian Empire – Israel's most feared enemy. Tonight we follow Jonah from the call, onto a ship heading the opposite way, and into a storm.

A LOOK AT THE HEBREW

- ***qum*** – קוּם "get up": God says "Get up, go" (1:2). Jonah does get up – but to flee (1:3). And the pagan captain later shakes him with the very same word: "Get up, call out to your god!" (1:6).
- ***yarad*** – יָרַד "go down": Jonah goes down to Joppa, down into the ship, down into its innermost part (1:3, 5). Every step away from God's call is a step downward, while Nineveh's evil "has come up" before God (1:2).
- ***tul*** – טוּל "hurl": The LORD hurls a great wind (1:4), the sailors hurl the cargo (1:5) and finally hurl Jonah (1:15). The same verb shows who is really in control of the storm.

DISCUSSION

1. What exactly does God ask Jonah to do, and what does Jonah do instead? Look closely at the words in verses 2 and 3. (Jonah 1:2–3)
2. Everything seems to go smoothly for Jonah: a ship is ready and he can pay the fare. Why is an "open door" not always proof of God's will? (Jonah 1:3)
3. While the sailors pray and work, Jonah sleeps. What does this picture tell us about spiritual numbness? (Jonah 1:5–6)
4. Jonah says, "A Hebrew am I, and the LORD, the God of heaven, I fear." In what way is his confession right, and in what way does his life contradict it? (Jonah 1:9)
5. The men "rowed hard" to reach land (literally, they "dug"). Where do we try to solve with our own strength something only obedience can solve? (Jonah 1:13)
6. The storm starts with men who fear the sea and ends with men who "feared the LORD with a great fear". What has God done through Jonah's disobedience? (Jonah 1:16)
7. What is your "Nineveh" – and your "Tarshish" – at the moment? Share only what you are comfortable sharing.

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Name one specific “Nineveh” (a conversation, an act of forgiveness, a task) and take one small step towards it this week.
- Notice one “Tarshish” you use to escape God's voice (busyness, screens, overwork) and set aside ten quiet minutes each day instead.

PRAY TOGETHER

Pray in pairs or threes: thank God that he pursues us even when we run, and ask him for the courage to “get up” in the one area each person named. Close by praying together for people who are suffering because of our own “storms”.

NOTES FOR THE LEADER

- This session covers three devotionals; you won't use every question. Choose four or five and give the last one enough time.
- Groups easily get stuck on whether a man could survive in a fish – that is next week. Gently keep the focus on Jonah's flight.
- Verse 1:6 is rich: a pagan sea captain says to the prophet what God said. Let the group discover this before you point it out.
- The question about “Nineveh” can touch painful relationships. Don't push anyone to share; offer to talk afterwards.
- Point ahead: in 1:15–16 Jonah is thrown into the sea so that others can live. Leave the Christ connection open for next week.

Related devotionals: Day 1 – The Call to Nineveh and the Flight to Tarshish · Day 2 – The Storm of Grace and the Sleeping Prophet · Day 3 – The Sacrifice in the Waves and the Sailors' Worship

Jonah 1:1–16

1 The word of the LORD came to Jonah son of
Amittai: 2 "Get up, go to Nineveh, the great city,
and cry out against it, for their evil has come up
before my face." 3 So Jonah got up – to flee to
Tarshish, away from the face of the LORD. He
went down to Joppa and found a ship bound for
Tarshish. He paid the fare and went down into
it, to go with them to Tarshish, away from the
face of the LORD.

4 But the LORD hurled a great wind onto the sea,
and there was a great storm on the sea, so that
the ship threatened to break apart. 5 The sailors
were afraid, and each cried out to his own god.
They hurled the cargo that was in the ship into
the sea to lighten it for themselves. But Jonah
had gone down into the innermost part of the
ship, had lain down, and had fallen into a deep
sleep. 6 The captain came to him and said to
him, "What are you doing asleep? Get up, call
out to your god! Perhaps that god will give a
thought to us, and we will not perish." 7 Then
they said to one another, "Come, let us cast lots,
so that we may know on whose account this evil
has come upon us." So they cast lots, and the lot
fell on Jonah. 8 Then they said to him, "Tell us,
please, on whose account this evil has come
upon us! What is your work, and where do you
come from? What is your country, and from
what people are you?" 9 He said to them, "A
Hebrew am I, and the LORD, the God of heaven, I
fear – he who made the sea and the dry land."
10 Then the men feared with a great fear and
said to him, "What is this you have done!" For
the men knew that he was fleeing from the face
of the LORD, because he had told them. 11 And
they said to him, "What shall we do to you, so
that the sea will calm down for us?" For the sea
was growing more and more stormy. 12 He said
to them, "Pick me up and hurl me into the sea,
and the sea will calm down for you. For I know
that it is on my account that this great storm
has come upon you." 13 The men rowed hard to
get back to dry land, but they could not, for the
sea was growing more and more stormy against
them. 14 Then they called out to the LORD and
said, "Please, LORD, do not let us perish for this
man's life, and do not lay innocent blood on us!
For you, LORD, have done as you pleased." 15 Then
they picked Jonah up and hurled him into the
sea, and the sea stopped its raging. 16 Then the
men feared the LORD with a great fear; they of-
fered a sacrifice to the LORD and made vows.

SESSION 2 · JONAH 2:1–11

From the Depths

THE BIG IDEA

At the lowest point of his flight, Jonah discovers that God was in charge all along – and that salvation belongs to the LORD alone.

TO GET STARTED

Think of a time when you were completely stuck – a flat tyre, a lost key, a cancelled flight. What went through your mind?

READ TOGETHER · JONAH 2:1–11

Let one person read 2:1–2 and 2:11 (the narrator), and another read the psalm (2:3–10) slowly, as a prayer.

TIMING

10 min	Welcome & opener
10 min	Read the passage
10 min	Background & Hebrew
40 min	Discussion
15 min	Application & prayer

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

Jonah has been thrown into the sea, and the storm has stopped. But the story is not over: the LORD appoints a great fish. From inside it, in total darkness, Jonah prays. Note: this chapter follows the Hebrew verse numbers – English Bibles number 2:1 as 1:17 and 2:2–11 as 2:1–10.

A LOOK AT THE HEBREW

- ***manah*** – מָנָה "appoint": God appoints the great fish (2:1) – and later the plant, the worm and the wind (4:6–8). The fish is not an accident or a punishment but God's chosen means of rescue.
- ***chesed*** – חֶסֶד "faithful love": God's loyal covenant love that never gives up. "Those who cling to worthless idols abandon their faithful love" (2:9): whatever we cling to instead of God robs us of it.
- ***yeshu'ah*** – יְשׁוּעָה "salvation": "Salvation belongs to the LORD!" (2:10). The name Yeshua – Jesus – comes from the same root.

DISCUSSION

1. How do you read the great fish: as punishment or as rescue? What does the word "appointed" suggest? (Jonah 2:1)
2. Jonah says to God, "You had thrown me into the deep" – although the sailors threw him. What does it mean to see God's hand behind our crisis? (Jonah 2:4)
3. "I am driven away from before your eyes. Yet I will look again towards your holy temple." What is the "yet" of faith, and where have you needed it? (Jonah 2:5)
4. "To the roots of the mountains I went down … But you brought my life up from the pit." How does this verse complete the "going down" we saw in chapter 1? (Jonah 2:7)
5. Jonah says, "I remembered the LORD" when his soul was fainting. What helps you to remember God when you are exhausted? (Jonah 2:8)
6. Jonah praises God before he is out of the fish. Why is praise in the dark so powerful – and so hard? (Jonah 2:10)

7. Jesus calls his death and resurrection “the sign of Jonah” (Matthew 12:40). Where do you see the gospel in this chapter?

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Learn one verse of Jonah's psalm by heart this week, so that you carry God's word with you into “dark” days.
- Name one “worthless idol” you cling to for security, and each day say aloud instead: “Salvation belongs to the LORD!”

PRAY TOGETHER

Read 2:3 together aloud. Then let each person who wishes name one situation where they need a “yet” of faith, and pray for each other briefly. Close by saying together: “Salvation belongs to the LORD!”

NOTES FOR THE LEADER

- Some will want to discuss whether the fish story is literal. Acknowledge the question briefly, then steer towards what the text emphasises: God's sovereignty and Jonah's prayer.
- Explain the verse numbering at the start, so that people using English Bibles are not confused.
- Jonah's psalm echoes many Psalms. If your group knows them, invite them to spot the echoes (e.g. Psalm 42:7 and 31:6 in English Bibles).
- Some members may be in a real “belly of the fish” – illness, loss, unemployment. Be gentle; don't suggest that every crisis is a punishment.
- Point ahead: Jonah promised to keep his vows (2:10). Next week we see whether he keeps them.

Related devotionals: Day 4 – The Abyss and the Great Fish God Appointed · Day 5 – Prayer from the Darkness: Salvation Belongs to the LORD

Jonah 2:1–11

[1] But the LORD appointed a great fish to swallow
Jonah. And Jonah was in the belly of the fish
three days and three nights. (*English Bibles*: 1:17)
[2] Then Jonah prayed to the LORD his God from
the belly of the fish [3] and said:

I called out of my distress to the LORD,
and he answered me;
from the belly of the grave I cried for help –
you heard my voice.
[4] You had thrown me into the deep,
into the heart of the seas,
and the current surrounded me;
all your breakers and your waves
passed over me.
[5] And I – I said, "I am driven away
from before your eyes.
Yet I will look again
towards your holy temple."
[6] Waters closed around me up to my throat,
the deep surrounded me,
seaweed was wrapped around my head.
[7] To the roots of the mountains I went down;
the earth – its bars closed behind me for ever.
But you brought my life up from the pit,
LORD my God.
[8] When my soul was fainting within me,
I remembered the LORD,
and my prayer came to you,
into your holy temple.
[9] Those who cling to worthless idols
abandon their faithful love.
[10] But I, with a voice of thanksgiving,
will sacrifice to you;
what I have vowed I will pay.
Salvation belongs to the LORD!

[11] Then the LORD spoke to the fish, and it vomited
Jonah out onto the dry land.

SESSION 3 · JONAH 3:1–10

Overturned

THE BIG IDEA

God speaks to his runaway prophet a second time, and a violent city believes God and turns – God's grace overturns hearts, not only cities.

TO GET STARTED

Have you ever been given a second chance – a second attempt at an exam, a job or a friendship? What did it feel like?

READ TOGETHER · JONAH 3:1–10

Use three voices: a narrator, the LORD *(v. 2) and the king's herald (vv. 7–9). Let one person read Jonah's one-line sermon in v. 4 slowly, with a pause before it.*

TIMING

10 min	Welcome & opener
10 min	Read the passage
10 min	Background & Hebrew
40 min	Discussion
15 min	Application & prayer

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

Jonah has just been vomited out onto the dry land. Chapter 3 opens almost word for word like chapter 1: the word of the LORD comes to Jonah a second time, with the same assignment. This time Jonah gets up and goes – and a sermon of just five Hebrew words sets off the greatest turning of a city in the Bible.

A LOOK AT THE HEBREW

- ***shenit*** **– שֵׁנִית** "a second time": One small word holds an ocean of grace. God could have chosen another prophet, but his word comes to Jonah again: his calling rests on his faithfulness, not on our failure.
- ***nehpakhet*** **– נֶהְפָּכֶת** "overturned": From hafakh, the word used for the destruction of Sodom (Genesis 19:25) – but it can also mean "turned around", "completely changed". Nineveh was indeed overturned within forty days: not by fire, but by repentance.
- ***shuv*** **– שׁוּב** "turn": The hinge of chapter 3. The people are to turn from their evil way (v. 8); the king hopes God may turn from his burning anger (v. 9); and when they turn, God relents of the evil he had said he would do (v. 10).

DISCUSSION

1. Put 1:1–3 and 3:1–3 side by side. What is the same, and what has changed? Notice the shift from "cry out against it" (1:2) to "cry out to it the message that I am telling you" (3:2). (Jonah 3:1)
2. Jonah's whole sermon is: "Forty more days, and Nineveh will be overturned!" What is missing from it? Why do you think it worked anyway? (Jonah 3:4)
3. "Overturned" can mean destroyed or turned around. In what sense was Nineveh "overturned" after all? (Jonah 3:10)
4. The turning starts among ordinary people and then reaches the throne. Look at the four things the king does in verse 6. What does each one say? (Jonah 3:6)
5. The king says, "Who knows? God may turn and relent." Compare the captain in 1:6: "Perhaps that god will give a thought to us." What do these two pagans understand about approaching God that Jonah seems to have forgotten? (Jonah 3:9)

6. "And God saw what they did, that they turned from their evil way." What does real turning look like in verses 8 and 10? What might "the violence that is in his hands" be for us today? (Jonah 3:8)
7. Nineveh was "a great city – great even before God". Whom have we written off as beyond God's reach? What would change if we saw them as great before God? (Jonah 3:3)

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Name one "point of disobedience" you need to go back to – something God asked of you that you left undone – and take the first "one day's journey" step this week.
- Choose one person or group you have written off. Pray for them by name every day this week.

PRAY TOGETHER

Thank God together that his word comes "a second time". Then hold a minute of silence in which each person brings before God what is in their hands that they need to let go of. Close by praying aloud, briefly and by name, for people and places that seem beyond reach.

NOTES FOR THE LEADER

- Some people carry real guilt about their own "Tarshish". Keep coming back to 3:1 – the word comes a second time. Question 6 can be answered in silence; no one should feel pressed to confess in the group.
- The historical background in Day 6 (plagues in 765 and 759 BC, the solar eclipse of 763 BC) helps explain Nineveh's openness. Mention it in two or three minutes; the point is the power of God's word, not the eclipse.
- Groups often get stuck on "God relented": does God change his mind? Day 7 points to Jeremiah 18:7–8 – God's character does not change; his dealings with a city change when it turns from its sin.
- The animals in sackcloth may draw a smile. Day 7 notes it was a known custom (Herodotus; Judith 4:10). Acknowledge it and move on.
- End by pointing ahead: in 3:10 God does not do "the evil". Next session opens with Jonah calling exactly that "a great evil".

Related devotionals: Day 6 – The God of Second Chances and the Cry in Nineveh · Day 7 – From the Throne to the Dust: Nineveh's Repentance and God's Grace

Jonah 3:1–10

[1] The word of the LORD came to Jonah a second
time: [2] "Get up, go to Nineveh, the great city,
and cry out to it the message that I am telling
you." [3] So Jonah got up and went to Nineveh, as
the LORD had said. Now Nineveh was a great city
– great even before God – a three days' journey
across. [4] Jonah began to go into the city, one
day's journey, and he cried out and said, "Forty
more days, and Nineveh will be overturned!"
[5] And the people of Nineveh believed God. They
called a fast and put on sackcloth, from the
greatest of them to the least. [6] When the word
reached the king of Nineveh, he got up from his
throne, took off his royal robe, covered himself
with sackcloth, and sat in the ashes. [7] And he
had it cried out in Nineveh and said: "By decree
of the king and his great men: let neither man
nor beast, herd nor flock taste anything; let
them not graze, and let them not drink water.
[8] Let man and beast be covered with sackcloth,
and let them call out to God with all their
strength. Let each one turn from his evil way
and from the violence that is in his hands.
[9] Who knows? God may turn and relent; he may
turn from his burning anger, so that we do not
perish." [10] And God saw what they did, that they
turned from their evil way. And God relented of
the evil that he had said he would do to them,
and he did not do it.

SESSION 4 · JONAH 4:1–11

The Unanswered Question

THE BIG IDEA

Jonah is angry that God is gracious. Through a plant, a worm and a scorching wind God exposes his small heart – and asks a question the book leaves open for us to answer: should I not have pity?

TIMING

10 min	Welcome & opener
10 min	Read the passage
10 min	Background & Hebrew
40 min	Discussion
15 min	Application & prayer

TO GET STARTED

What small thing can ruin your mood in an instant – a hot day, a slow internet connection, a missed bus? What does that say about us?

READ TOGETHER · JONAH 4:1–11

Read it as a dialogue with three voices: narrator, Jonah and the LORD. *After the last question in verse 11, leave a moment of silence – the book gives no answer.*

WHERE WE ARE IN THE STORY

Nineveh has been spared. Instead of rejoicing, Jonah is furious – and now we finally learn why he ran to Tarshish. He sits east of the city to see what will happen, and God teaches him with a plant, a worm and a scorching east wind. The book ends with God's question, and no answer from Jonah.

A LOOK AT THE HEBREW

- ***ra'ah gedolah*** – רָעָה גְּדוֹלָה "a great evil": Nineveh's evil came up before God (1:2); they turned from their evil way (3:8); God relented of the evil (3:10). Now: "But to Jonah this was evil – a great evil." God's grace itself is evil in Jonah's eyes.
- ***charah*** – חָרָה "anger burned": The moment God's burning anger stops (3:9), Jonah's starts. God answers with a quiet question, as he did with Cain (Genesis 4:6): "Is it right for your anger to burn?"
- ***chus*** – חוּס "have pity": Jonah has compassion – but for a plant that was "a son of a night". God argues from the lesser to the greater: if you pity the plant, should I not have pity on Nineveh?

DISCUSSION

1. Read 4:1–2. Why did Jonah really run to Tarshish? How does this change the way you read chapter 1? (Jonah 4:2)
2. Jonah quotes Israel's great confession – "a gracious and compassionate God, slow to anger and abounding in faithful love" (Exodus 34:6) – as an accusation. How can we know true things about God and still resent them? (Jonah 4:2)
3. God answers Jonah's outburst with a question: "Is it right for your anger to burn?" Why a question and not a rebuke? What is God doing? (Jonah 4:4)
4. The plant is the only thing in the whole book that makes Jonah happy (4:6); the heat makes him want to die (4:8). What do our joys and our anger reveal about what we value most? (Jonah 4:6)
5. God "appointed" the fish, the plant, the worm and the wind. What does it mean that even the worm was appointed? Have you known a "worm" like that? (Jonah 4:7)

6. Read 4:10–11. Compare what Jonah pities with what God pities. What argument is God making – and why does he mention the animals at the very end? (Jonah 4:11)
7. The book ends with a question. How would you answer it – for yourself, and for the "Nineveh" in your own life that you find hard to love? (Jonah 4:11)

FOR THE WEEK AHEAD

- Think of one person you hold an "older brother" resentment against (Luke 15:25–32). Pray a blessing on them every day this week.
- Write down your own one-sentence answer to God's question in 4:11, and share it with one person in the group.

PRAY TOGETHER

Begin with a minute of silence before God's question in 4:11. Then pray for the people and places we find hard to love, and thank God that he is "slow to anger and abounding in faithful love" – towards them, and towards us.

NOTES FOR THE LEADER

- This session covers three devotionals (Days 8–10) and a long chapter. If time is short, combine questions 4 and 5, or give the session 15 extra minutes.
- Jonah twice wishes to die (4:3, 4:8). Handle this with care: someone in the group may know despair from the inside. Keep the focus on God's patient response, don't make light of it, and offer to talk afterwards.
- The "older brother" in Luke 15 is a helpful bridge, but keep the focus on our own hearts, not on judging Jonah – or others in the room.
- Day 10 suggests that Jonah himself may have written the book as his confession. Present this as a possibility, not a fact.
- This is the last session. Keep ten minutes at the end to look back over all four chapters: which image or question will people take with them?
- After the final reading, don't fill the silence too quickly. The open question is the point.

Related devotionals: Day 8 – The Displeased Prophet: When God's Grace Makes Us Angry · Day 9 – The Plant, the Worm and the Scorching East Wind · Day 10 – The Unanswered Question: God's Father-Heart and Our Small-Heartedness

Jonah 4:1–11

[1] But to Jonah this was evil – a great evil – and
his anger burned. [2] He prayed to the LORD and
said, "Please, LORD, is this not what I said while I
was still in my own country? That is why I fled
to Tarshish in the first place. For I knew that
you are a gracious and compassionate God,
slow to anger and abounding in faithful love,
and one who relents over evil. [3] So now, LORD,
please take my life from me, for my death is bet-
ter than my life." [4] But the LORD said, "Is it right
for your anger to burn?" [5] Jonah went out of the
city and sat down east of the city. There he
made himself a shelter and sat under it in the
shade, until he could see what would happen in
the city. [6] Then the LORD God appointed a leafy
plant and made it grow up over Jonah, to be
shade over his head, to deliver him from his
evil. And Jonah rejoiced over the plant with
great joy. [7] But God appointed a worm when
dawn came up the next day, and it struck the
plant, so that it withered. [8] When the sun rose,
God appointed a scorching east wind, and the
sun struck Jonah's head, so that he grew faint.
He asked that he might die, and said, "My death
is better than my life." [9] But God said to Jonah,
"Is it right for your anger to burn over the
plant?" He said, "It is right for my anger to burn
– to the point of death!" [10] Then the LORD said,
"You had pity on the plant, for which you did
not labour and which you did not make grow; it
came into being in a night and perished in a
night. [11] And should I not have pity on Nineveh,
the great city, in which there are more than a
hundred and twenty thousand people who do
not know their right hand from their left – and
many animals as well?"